# Lights Still On Toolkit

NCCADV
North Carolina Coalition
Against Domestic Violence

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The information, guidance, and recommendations contained within this manual reflect current best practices and knowledge shared by the NCCADV. As standards, research, and professional understanding evolve, best practices may also change. Users of this manual are encouraged to stay informed of new developments and adapt their approaches accordingly. This manual is intended as a resource and should not replace professional judgment or organizational policies.

This toolkit was created by Alyssa Corrado, Legal and Policy Intern, with guidance and support from Nisha Williams, Legal Director, and Ruhani Amin, Communications and Data Visualization Coordinator. We are especially grateful to NCCADV team members Elizabeth Sager, Taylor Neal, Cassandra Rowe, and Quisha Mallette for their valuable expertise, thoughtful feedback, and contributions, which helped shape this resource.

For more information, please contact: North Carolina Coalition Against Domestic Violence
contact@nccadv.org

# Find the Trailor and Movie Here:

## Watch the trailer here:

https://youtu.be/LHSlw9W0yg4

## Watch the full video here:

https://youtu.be/rvpmNzFEMUY

# About Lights Still On

Lights Still On was created to highlight the experiences of domestic violence agencies across North Carolina and to examine how ongoing funding challenges have affected both advocates and the services available to survivors. Through agency perspectives, workforce experiences, and an analysis of trends related to federal funding reductions, the lasting impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic, rising operational costs, and increasing service demands, the film explores the factors contributing to advocate burnout, workforce turnover, and resource limitations within the domestic violence field.

The film seeks to elevate the voices of those working on the front lines while drawing attention to the critical role that sustainable funding plays in ensuring the safety of survivors and their access to services. It demonstrates that domestic violence programs are more than organizations, they are lifelines that provide crisis intervention, emergency shelter, legal advocacy, counseling, prevention education, and pathways to healing.

Lights Still On reminds us that healing, safety, and hope do not happen alone. Behind every survivor served is an advocate, a crisis counselor, a shelter bed, a case manager, and a community committed to keeping the lights on. As domestic violence programs face increasing financial challenges, sustaining these resources is not only an investment in services, it is an investment in safety, dignity, and the possibility of a future free from violence.

# Reflect

**Here are some questions to think about as you are watching the film. Feel free to reflect silently or share with other advocates, friends, and neighbors.**

## Before you watch

How important do you believe domestic violence programs are to community safety?

How has the lack of funding affected DV agencies and their ability to serve survivors?

What do you think happens when funding for victim services is reduced?

## After you watch

How did the film deepen your understanding of the challenges survivors face when seeking help?

How did the film challenge or reinforce your understanding of domestic violence?

How might funding shortages affect the outcomes depicted in the film?

## Community Reviews

**“Years of insufficient funding have deeply impacted survivors’ pathways towards safety and healing”**

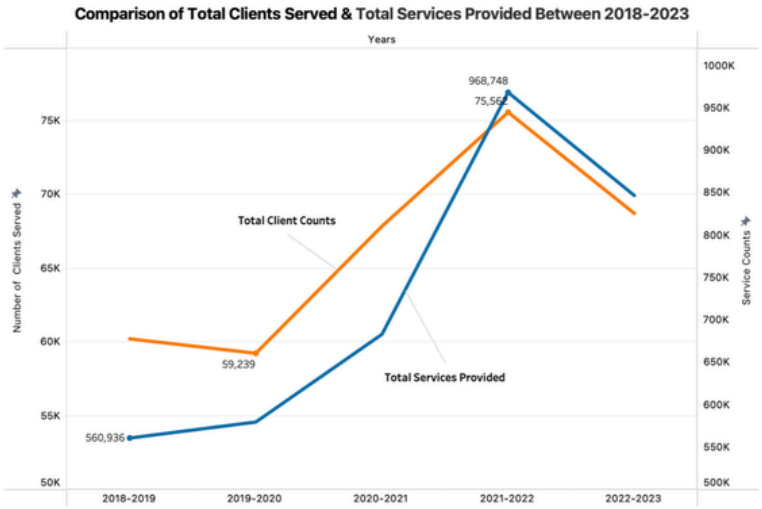
**“We serve all and live all over the state; it is important that people realize that the funding affects everybody and everyone in our community – this movie shows that”**

**“Every single walk of life is affected by the lack of funding”**

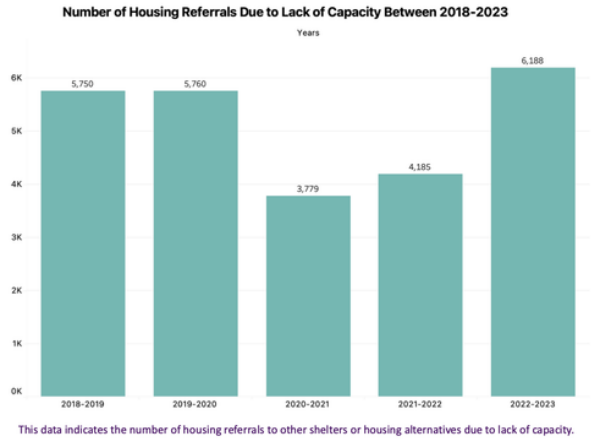
# Taking a Look at the Data

**At NCCADV, a 5-Year Trend Analysis of Domestic Violence Data in North Carolina was conducted to highlight key trends in DV data over 5 years (2018-2023), with a focus on insights relevant to the challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic.**

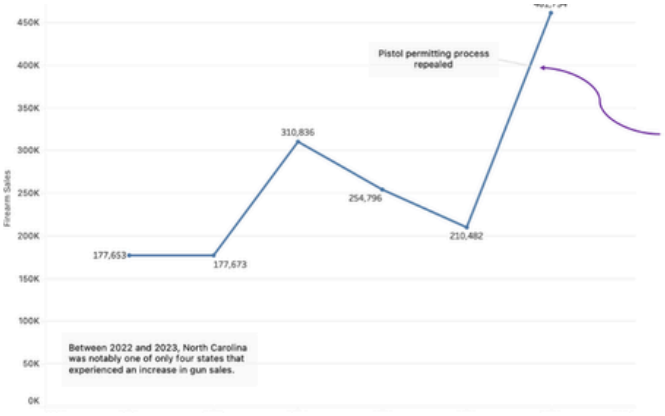
**The demand for domestic violence services continues to exceed available resources across North Carolina. Service requests increased by 75% between 2018 and 2021 and remain approximately 50% higher than pre-pandemic levels. In 2023 alone, more than 6,000 survivors seeking shelter were turned away because agencies lacked the capacity to meet demand. At the same time, Victims of Crime Act (VOCA) funding has declined by 76%, dropping from $103 million in 2018 to $24.6 million in 2024.**



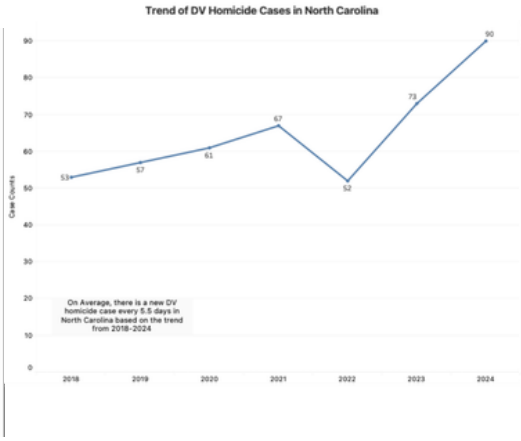

This graph shows that while clients served trended upward (lefthand axis on the graph), services needed (righthand axis on the graph) climbed even higher, showing that per client, more services were asked for/required. The needs remained high after the height of COVID, straining DV agency resources.




This data indicates the number of housing referrals to other shelters or housing alternatives due to lack of capacity.




The repeal of North Carolina's pistol permitting process (annotated in the graph) is correlated with a noticeable rise in firearm sales in North Carolina. The overall trend, including the dip in 2022, mimics the above graph showing the increases in DV homicides. This trend highlights the immediate impact of the pistol permitting repeal, potential continued risks of reduced regulation, and the need for further policy scrutiny.



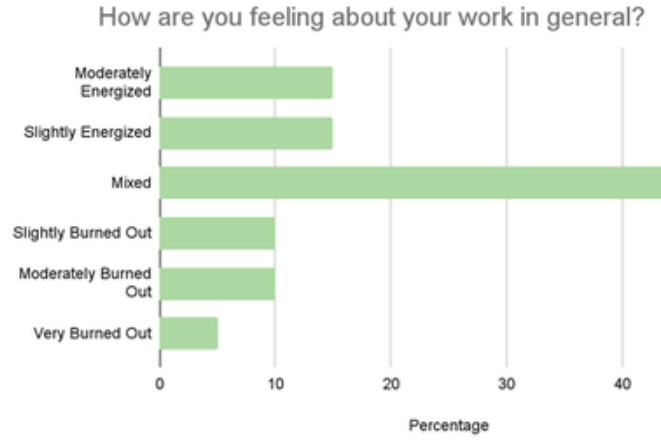

**As agencies struggle to meet growing needs and the challenges of COVID-19, domestic violence-related homicides continue to rise. North Carolina recorded 93 domestic violence homicides in 2024, nearly 70% more than six years earlier. In the first three months of 2025, 19 people were killed, with half of those deaths involving intimate partner murder-suicides. Firearms were involved in nearly all of these fatalities, highlighting the increasingly lethal nature of domestic violence and the critical need for sustained investment in survivor services and prevention efforts.**

It is incredibly important for domestic violence service providers to be incredibly visible in communities, so survivors are aware that help is there

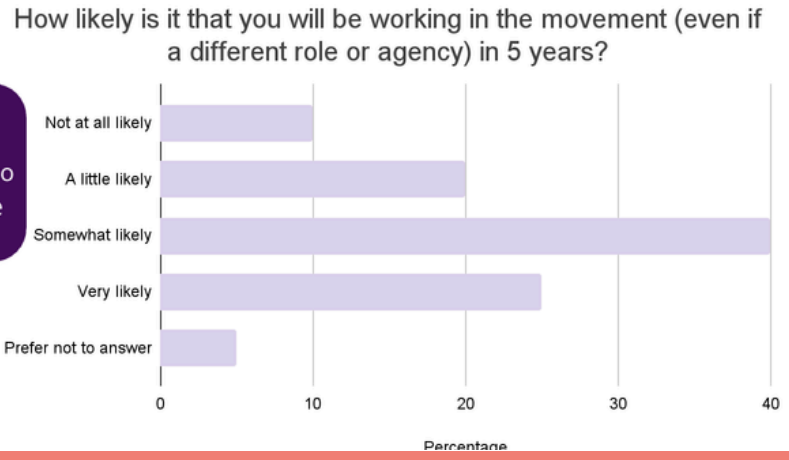
# Restoryation in NC

**To understand the effects of COVID-19 and its impact on DV agencies, NCCADV joined with 24 other state coalitions to better understand the needs of professional domestic violence advocates. To gather insights, storytelling circles were convened where advocates could share their experiences and connect with other advocates while integrating data collection through demographic and reflective surveys. The ReStoryation project in North Carolina has provided critical insights into the needs and experiences of domestic violence advocates, particularly during the peak of the COVID-19 pandemic.**

**A total of 1,322 domestic and sexual violence providers completed the ReStoryation survey nationally. The majority of participants identified as female, heterosexual, and aged 18 to 44. Nearly 50% of these workers are survivors themselves and share their experiences to educate and connect with others. Most worked directly with survivors, underscoring the need to address burnout and vicarious trauma in the field. The mental strain experienced by advocates was intensified by financial and emotional hardships resulting from the pandemic. In the aftermath, worker challenges were compounded by job insecurity and staff turnover.**




> Several staff took extended leaves of absence, there was significant agency turnover and restructure, several people got pushed out of the agency, my team was completely turned over mostly due to mental health/burnout issues.




> We need "a focus on the ones doing the boots [on the ground] work - not just looking at the clients served but also looking at who is providing these services and how we are supporting them."

**The ReStoryation report highlights the emotional, financial, and structural challenges faced by the advocacy workforce and emphasizes the importance of workplace wellness and support systems. The findings underscore the urgent need for trauma-informed workplace policies, consistent funding, and enhanced mental health and financial support for advocates.**



**Part of doing this work is not just meeting the needs of survivors today, but working to prevent DV in the future.**

**When programs are cut its not just funding that is lost but the ability to keep the lights on.**

# CALL TO ACTION



- Refer a Friend in Need to a Local DV Agency.
- Volunteer
- Reach Out to Your Legislation and Local Representative
- Donate to NCCADV or Your Local DV Agency.

**Your contributions help us support statewide policies and programs that protect survivors and prevent harm. Your support helps us empower local agencies to serve survivors in their communities**

# What does your donation go towards?

Training
Emergency Financial Assitance
Salaries
Furniture
Gas Cards
Relocation
Hope
Office Supplies
Interpreter Services
Phone Lines
Keeping the lights on
Independence
Courage
Support Groups

# Funding is safety.

Court Advocates
Shelter
Hygiene Products
Healing
Diapers
Clothes
Prevention Educators
Food
Counselors & Therapists
Crisis Hotlines
Empowerment
Computers
Emergency Hotel Stays
Case Managers
Transportation

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# RESOURCE LIBRARY ON FUNDING CUT IMPACT

## NCCADV resources

Homicide data on the NCCADV website

NNEDV DV counts one-pager handout

2026 Advocacy Day

Read the Full article for the National ReStoryation Project

## News

Funding cuts article (19th News)

## Foundation & Grants Information

NC Center for Nonprofits

Cause IQ

https://www.nccommunityfoundation.org

Office of State Budget and Management

Resilience Exchange

## VOCA information

Violence Office Against Women - Homepage

## VAWA resources

VAWA - HUD

Women's Law

# About the Director



Richard Abiona is a communications professional and visual storyteller with a growing interest in technology and innovation, working at the intersection of media, advocacy, and emerging tech. His work focuses on amplifying the voices of underserved communities and supporting advocacy through compelling visual and written narratives. Before moving to the United States, Richard spent several years working with nonprofit organizations in Nigeria on initiatives addressing gender-based violence, police accountability, and COVID-19 relief for vulnerable communities. He holds a master's degree in Communication from North Carolina State University and is currently pursuing a master's degree in Technology Management at North Carolina A&T State University, where he serves as a Graduate Teaching Assistant. Most recently, he directed and edited Lights Still On, a documentary exploring the impact of funding cuts on domestic violence services, produced for the North Carolina Coalition Against Domestic Violence. Through his work, Richard seeks to tell stories that inform, inspire, and drive meaningful change.

richardabiona007@gmail.com

# Meet the Cast



Carianne Fisher, NCCADV Executive Director, joined the staff at NCCADV in November 2019. She began her social work career as a weekend advocate at a domestic violence shelter in St. Louis. Carianne later joined the team at a private child welfare agency in Illinois for over 16 years. She began as a Family Counselor in a program serving youth who ran away from home in Southern Illinois. She later served as Training Coordinator, Director of Professional Education and Training, and Director of Human Resources and Training. Carianne was also the Human Resources Manager for a skilled nursing facility, a Field Consultant for the University of Chicago, and the Director of Training at Cook County Juvenile Temporary Detention Center. Before joining NCCADV, Carianne served as the first Executive Director of Therapet, an animal-assisted therapy nonprofit in Tyler, TX. Carianne received both a B.A. in English Literature and an MSW from Washington University in St Louis.

cfisher@nccadv.org, www.nccadv.org



Nisha G. Williams is a dedicated attorney with a strong emphasis on domestic violence law. As the Legal Director at the North Carolina Coalition Against Domestic Violence (NCCADV), she plays a vital role in assisting survivors in obtaining restraining orders and ensuring they receive trauma-informed legal support through statewide training and advocacy initiatives. Deeply committed to ending domestic violence, she actively advocates for systemic changes that empower survivors and improve access to justice in the community.

Nwilliams@nccadv.org, www.nccadv.org



Ruhani Amin is the Communications and Data Visualization Coordinator at the North Carolina Coalition Against Domestic Violence (NCCADV). In this role, she leads digital communications and transforms complex data into accessible, actionable information for advocates, policymakers, and communities across North Carolina. She manages the Coalition's digital resources, creates data visualizations and develops reports that support evidence-informed decision-making in domestic violence prevention and survivor advocacy. Ruhani holds a Master of Science in Information Technology and Management with a concentration in Business Analytics from the University of North Carolina at Greensboro. Her expertise combines data analysis, visualization, and strategic communications to help translate research and program data into practical tools that strengthen prevention efforts and inform public policy. She is passionate about using data storytelling to make information more accessible and drive meaningful change.

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**A heartfelt thank you to our interviewees for sharing their time, voices, and expertise. Their perspectives helped bring Lights Still On to life and underscore the importance of sustaining survivor services. We are grateful for your contributions and continued commitment to this work.**

# Meet the Cast

Patricia A. Harris is the Founder and Executive Director of Women Veterans Support Services, Inc. (WVSS, Inc.), North Carolina's first nonprofit dedicated to supporting women veterans and their families. A U.S. Army combat veteran, servant leader, domestic violence (DV) and military sexual trauma (MST) survivor, and military culture consultant, Patricia has transformed her own journey into a mission of hope and healing for others. For nearly two decades, she has stood beside survivors, helping them find safety, strength, and a path forward. Her passion is rooted in the belief that every survivor deserves to be seen, heard, and supported with dignity and compassion. Patricia's message is simple yet powerful: No veteran or survivor should ever have to suffer in silence.

p.harris@wvss-nc.org, www.wvssnc.org



Monica Kearney is the Executive Director of NC Safe Space, a non-profit organization that is committed to reducing relationship violence and sexual assault in Franklin County, North Carolina, and nearby communities.
https://www.ncsafespace.org

Shequana Pulliam serves as the Prevention Specialist for Domestic Violence Shelter and Services, Inc. (DVSS) in Wilmington, North Carolina. In this role, she collaborates with the North Carolina Coalition Against Domestic Violence (NCCADV) and the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) to strengthen trauma-informed support systems for local direct service providers. Her work focuses on promoting economic stability, supporting agency policies through partnerships with local businesses, and fostering positive community norms by creating opportunities for teens to engage in meaningful conversations with their peers about issues that matter to them. In January 2024, Shequana initiated the development of a Violence Prevention Coordinated Community Response Team (CCRT) to bridge service gaps and strengthen collaboration among community partners. Through this initiative, she works to address the intersection of shared risk and protective factors across agencies, creating a more coordinated and comprehensive approach to violence prevention throughout the community. Shequana is the mother of two beautiful young women and a member of Delta Sigma Theta Sorority, Incorporated. She also received her Community Resilience Model (CRM)Teaching Certification in August of 2025.
https://domesticviolence-wilm.org

Shaye Lloyd is the Program Director of Southern Queer Survivor Network at the LGBTQ Center of Durham. The Center is dedicated to supporting LGBTQ+ people through services, programming, resources, and support networks that center their wellbeing and allow them to thrive.
https://www.sqsn.org/our-staff &
https://www.lgbtqcenterofdurham.org



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